Leaving aside an ideological or geopolitical common end, the cohering factor of the BRICS bloc is an attempt to bend the rules of those institutions slightly in their own favour – but not really to replace them. Their growing incursion across the Global South will not by any magic touch open up developmental pathways out of poverty and dependency. We see this most clearly in Africa.

The voracious appetite of China, India and increasingly Brazil for cheap resources is behind the GDP figures that have triggered the business media's sudden rebranding of the region from a 'hopeless continent' to 'Africa Rising', no matter that in reality this means intensified looting and Africans *up*rising. Trade between the BRICS bloc and Africa jumped by more than 70% between 2008 and 2012 to US$340 billion (more than between BRICS nations themselves). The growth is based almost entirely on primary exports, overwhelmingly oil, giving it an extremely uneven geography that only includes certain countries. Once resource depletion, environmental degradation and other factors are netted out of notoriously sketchy GDP estimates, the optimism seems misplaced – with negative per capita wealth accumulation. The World Bank estimated that by 2007 Africa was losing 6% of its annual income, with these corrections, and that doesn't include the illicit capital flight that accompanies extraction industries.

On top of this we must factor in broader political-economic effects of resource-curse-driven growth – the undergirding of a parasitic elite, a state–corporate revolving-door relationship replete with brutal policing, ecological devastation, rampant inequality and de-industrialisation. In South Africa we have a word that signifies this resource curse: *Marikana*. The rush of BRICS corporates and states for land grabs, financial gaming and resource extraction has generated talk of a new 'scramble for Africa' reminiscent of the one launched at a Berlin conference 130 years ago, when the continent's irrational borders were drawn. BRICS are helping to reproduce Africa's traditional role as a peripheral supplier of cheap labour and resources and an outlet for selling manufactured goods, and not transcending that role.

South Africa has had a crucial part to play in this, justifying its seat at the table, despite its dwarfish size, by its position as the 'gateway to Africa'. The foreign policy that Thabo Mbeki pioneered is mainly geared to opening the continent to penetration by Western and non-Western multinationals through financial and trade liberalisation. South Africa relates to its hinterlands in a similar fashion to other BRICS – with over 80% of imports composed of minerals and energy but still running a trade surplus from its exports of manufactures. South African retail, cellphone, banking and mining corporates are rapidly fanning out across the continent. Sandton's sophisticated financial institutions are positioned as the